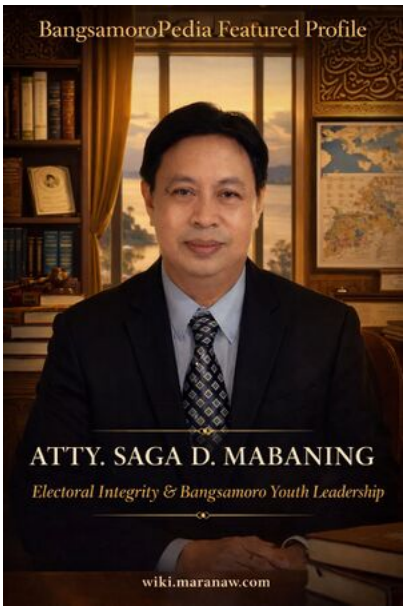
Saga D. Mabaning

Atty. Saga D. Mabaning is a distinguished Maranao legal professional, public servant, and youth advocate whose career has centered on electoral integrity, Bangsamoro regional governance, and the empowerment of Muslim youth through values-based leadership and interfaith dialogue. His work bridges high-level legal policy with grassroots youth mentorship, reflecting a lifetime commitment to integrating Islamic principles with modern democratic governance in the emerging Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

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Saga D. Mabaning



Full Name	Saga D. Mabaning
Ethnic Affiliation	Maranao
Profession	Attorney, Government Official, Youth Advocate
Known For	Electoral Integrity, BARMM Governance, Muslim Youth Leadership
Organization	World Assembly of Muslim Youth (WAMY) Philippines, Commission on Elections (COMELEC)
Religion	Islam

Early Life and Cultural Foundation

Atty. Mabaning belongs to the Maranao ethnic group, the "People of the Lake," whose heartland centers on Lanao del Sur in the Bangsamoro region. Growing up immersed in a culture deeply rooted in Islamic tradition and Maranao custom, his upbringing emphasized the values of *Maratabat* (dignity and honor), community responsibility, and education as a pathway to service. The Maranao worldview, shaped by both pre-Islamic and Islamic heritage, taught him early that education and integrity were not personal achievements but duties owed to family, community, and faith.

His formative years in Lanao del Sur connected him to the region's rich intellectual and spiritual traditions. The province has long produced scholars, leaders, and advocates who navigate the complex terrain of faith, governance, and cultural preservation. Mabaning's own journey followed this pattern, blending secular legal training with a lifelong engagement with Islamic jurisprudence and Bangsamoro political development.

Education and Legal Formation

Mabaning earned his Juris Doctor (JD) degree through rigorous academic study in the Philippines, building the legal foundation that would enable him to practice before the Philippine Bar and work at the intersection of law and public administration. His legal education was not merely secular. Throughout his studies and practice, he remained committed to understanding how Islamic jurisprudence (Fiqh) and modern constitutional law could coexist and strengthen democratic governance in the BARMM.

His formation as a lawyer occurred during a transformative period in Philippine legal history. The move toward Muslim autonomy and later the passage of the Bangsamoro Organic Law created urgent need for legal experts who understood both national constitutional frameworks and the aspirations of Bangsamoro peoples for self-governance. Mabaning positioned himself to answer that need.

Professional Career

Role at the Commission on Elections

Atty. Mabaning served as a Director at the Commission on Elections (COMELEC), one of the Philippines' three constitutional commissions. In this capacity, he played a vital role in managing electoral processes and addressing critical issues such as the relationship between technology and democratic integrity in the Philippines' voting systems.

His work at COMELEC coincided with a pivotal moment in Philippine electoral history. The move toward BARMM's first parliamentary elections required new legal frameworks and careful coordination between national electoral bodies and regional governance structures. As a COMELEC Director, Mabaning contributed to discussions about how the national electoral body could support the BARMM's unique parliamentary system while maintaining the standards expected of Philippine elections.

Legal Contributions to the Bangsamoro Electoral Code

Mabaning's most significant legal contribution has been his instrumental role in shaping and advising on the Bangsamoro Electoral Code, formally enacted as Bangsamoro Autonomy Act (BAA) No. 35 in March 2023. This landmark legislation established the legal framework for electoral governance in the BARMM and reflects careful negotiation between regional autonomy and national constitutional requirements.<ref>Bangsamoro Electoral Code of 2023, Articles I-VI, Bangsamoro Gazette. 2023.</ref>

His specific contributions to the Electoral Code centered on several critical areas:

- **Structural Alignment**: He was a key voice in ensuring that the Electoral Code remained consistent with national election laws while accommodating the BARMM's innovative parliamentary form of government. This required translating the Bangsamoro Organic Law's framework into practical electoral procedures.

- **Party System Architecture**: Mabaning provided legal guidance during the transition from traditional localized elective structures to the party-centered model that defines the BARMM Parliament. This shift represents a fundamental change in how Bangsamoro governance operates, moving from individual-based contests to party-based representation with proportional allocation.

- **Electoral Integrity and Moral Governance**: He has been a vocal advocate for the Electoral Code's "moral governance" provisions, which aim to foster genuinely principled political parties and reduce the influence of

political dynasties in the region. His position reflects a belief that electoral codes do more than manage voting logistics. They shape the character of political life.

- **Addressing Constitutional Complexities**: Mabaning has engaged with the legal challenges surrounding redistricting laws and the multiple postponements of BARMM elections. The exclusion of Sulu from the BARMM by Supreme Court order created unprecedented legal and constitutional questions about how to allocate parliamentary seats fairly. His work has focused on ensuring that the legal roadmap for elections remains constitutionally sound despite these challenges.

World Assembly of Muslim Youth (WAMY) Philippines

Beyond his government roles, Atty. Mabaning has emerged as a prominent figure within the World Assembly of Muslim Youth (WAMY) Philippines, an international Islamic educational organization committed to youth leadership development and interfaith understanding. WAMY operates in 56 countries and is recognized by the United Nations as a humanitarian and relief-works organization.<ref>World Assembly of Muslim Youth. "About WAMY." UN Yearbook Profile. Retrieved 2024.</ref>

Within WAMY Philippines, Mabaning has served as both mentor and director, focusing on values-based leadership for young Muslims navigating multicultural societies. His philosophy, often encapsulated in the phrase "You Are the Leader," challenges youth to take initiative regardless of their current status or position. This teaching reflects both Islamic concepts of responsibility (*Amanah*) and the Maranao tradition of community leadership.

He has represented the Philippines at international youth forums, including the Australia-Southeast Asia Muslim Youth Summit, where he has spoken on the role of young Muslims in multicultural democracies and the integration of traditional values with global standards. His mentorship emphasizes that leadership is a *trust* placed by the community and that Muslims in the 21st century must engage in both spiritual formation and practical skill development.

Contributions to Interfaith Harmony

A defining thread in Mabaning's public work has been his advocacy for interfaith dialogue and mutual understanding between Muslims and Christians in Mindanao. He has been a vocal proponent of highlighting theological similarities between Islam and Christianity, particularly in their shared emphasis on justice, mercy, and human dignity. This work carries significant weight in Mindanao's context, where decades of conflict have left deep communal wounds.

His interfaith initiatives seek to move beyond symbolic gestures toward substantive engagement. By bringing together Muslim and Christian leaders to discuss shared values and common concerns, he has worked to demonstrate that religious difference need not produce enmity and that shared governance frameworks can respect faith commitments on all sides.

Recognition of Bangsamoro Qur'anic Excellence

Mabaning has been instrumental in promoting government recognition of Bangsamoro Qur'an reciters and scholars, elevating the status of Islamic spiritual education within the region's official identity. The BARMM has increasingly recognized that preserving Bangsamoro culture includes honoring the region's tradition of Qur'anic scholarship and recitation.

His advocacy in this area reflects a conviction that regional identity encompasses spiritual heritage. For Muslim Filipinos, and particularly for Maranaos, the Qur'an represents not merely a religious text but a foundation of civilization, culture, and learning. By promoting the recognition of accomplished reciters and scholars, Mabaning has helped embed Islamic intellectual tradition within the BARMM's official identity and institutional structures.

Personal Philosophy and Values

Mabaning's life and work are guided by three foundational principles: integrity, service, and faith. These are not abstract ideals but lived commitments evident in how he approaches professional challenges and mentors young people.

His philosophy bridges the traditional Maranao value of *Maratabat* (dignity, honor, and proper conduct) with the Islamic concept of *Ihsan* (excellence in service and worship). In his teaching and advocacy, he suggests that leaders must pursue *Ihsan* in every action, striving not merely to meet minimum legal or professional standards but to exemplify excellence in thought, speech, and deed. This fusion of cultural and religious values gives his work a distinctive character.

The concept of *Amanah* (trust, responsibility) is central to his mentorship philosophy. Leaders, in his view, do not hold power for personal advancement. They hold a trust on behalf of their community. This understanding shapes how he approaches both legal work in government and mentorship in youth organizations.

Recognition and Representation

Mabaning has represented the Philippines and the Bangsamoro at multiple international forums, including Global Youth Summit initiatives focused on sustainable development and community resilience. These platforms have allowed him to articulate Bangsamoro perspectives on youth leadership, Islamic governance, and peacebuilding to global audiences.

His participation in regional dialogues on peace and development reflects the BARMM's positioning within broader Indo-Pacific conversations about governance innovation and religious plurality. By bringing Bangsamoro voices to these forums, he has helped ensure that the region's unique experiences and insights contribute to global thinking about democracy, faith, and social development.

Legacy and Ongoing Work

Atty. Saga D. Mabaning's career exemplifies the generation of Bangsamoro leaders who have embraced the task of building democratic institutions grounded in both constitutional principles and Islamic values. His contributions to the Bangsamoro Electoral Code have created a legal foundation for parliamentary democracy in the BARMM. His mentorship through WAMY has shaped young Muslim leaders who will navigate the 21st century. His advocacy for interfaith understanding has built bridges in a region learning to move beyond conflict.

His work remains ongoing. The first regular Bangsamoro Parliament election, now scheduled for September 14, 2026, will test the electoral framework to which Mabaning contributed significantly. The youth he has mentored will carry his teachings about integrity, service, and excellence into their own leadership roles. The interfaith dialogues he has initiated will continue to bear fruit in communities where Muslims and Christians work together for common development.

The signature of Mabaning's legacy is this: he has insisted that law and governance are not merely technical matters. They are expressions of community values and reflections of fundamental commitments to justice, dignity, and the common good. In bridging legal expertise with spiritual principle, in connecting youth empowerment with electoral integrity, he has modeled what it means to serve the Bangsamoro not as an administrator but as a steward of its future.

Further Reading

- Bangsamoro Organic Law (Republic Act No. 11054). 2018.
- Bangsamoro Electoral Code (Bangsamoro Autonomy Act No. 35). March 2023.
- World Assembly of Muslim Youth Official Website (https://www.wamy.org/)
- Bangsamoro Parliament Official Website (https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/)

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Electoral Systems of the Philippines
- Maranao people
- History of Muslim Filipino Leadership

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